ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Meaning and Structure

University of Glasgow

Everyone Needs More Meaning in Their Life

Marc Alexander

Week 8

Meaning and Structure

the meaning part

- *Week 8:* Meaning and the World
- *Week 9:* Meaning and Words
- *Week 10:* Change in Meaning
- *Week 11:* Extending Meaning

Meaning and Grammar

- **Closed class words:** pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, determiners, prepositions, etc
- **Open class words:** nouns, verbs, adverbs, and adjectives
- The closed classes often carry a **grammatical meaning** (‘this is in the future’, ‘this is definite’, ‘these things are alternates’, ‘this is certain’, ‘this is on top of something else’); these are meanings which function to indicate relationships between open-class words
- The open classes often carry a **lexical meaning**…

Lexical Meaning

- **Closed class words:** pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, determiners, prepositions, etc
- **Open class words:** nouns, verbs, adverbs, and adjectives
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- The open classes often carry a **lexical meaning**…

wing

NOUN

Factsheet

- Etymology
- ▸ Meaning & use
- Pronunciation
- Forms
- Frequency
- ▸ Compounds & derived words

QUOTATIONS

Hide all quotations

EARLIER VERSION

wing, n. in OED Second Edition (1989)

IN OTHER DICTIONARIES

wing(e, n. in Middle English Dictionary

Etymology

Summary

A borrowing from early Scandinavian.

Middle English, first in plural forms *wenge*, *wengen*, *wenges*, **< Old Norse** *vængir*, accusative *vængi*, plural of *vængr* (**Swedish**, **Danish** *vinge*) wing of a bird, aisle, etc.; replacing **Old English** *feþra* wings...

Show more

Cite

Meaning & use

I. The limb of a bird, and related uses.

I.1.a. Each of the organs of flight of any flying animal, as a bird, bat, or insect. **c1175–**

In birds the wings are specially modified fore-limbs; in bats (and the extinct pterodactyls, etc.), extensions of the skin attached to modified parts of the fore-limbs (see **bat** *n.*[1]); in insects, membranous expansions attached to the thorax in addition to the limbs. In a few birds the wings are rudimentary, and either functionless (as in the *Apteryx*) or used only to assist in swimming or walking (as in Penguins).

punch

VERB[1]

QUOTATIONS

Hide all quotations

CONTENTS

I. To poke or prick.
▶ I.1. transitive and (rare) intransitive. To push, poke, prod, or...
▶ I.2. † transitive and (rare) intransitive. To stab, prick, or...
II. To indent, pierce, or perforate using a punch.
II.3. transitive. To emboss (plate or other metalwork) as a...
▶ II.4. transitive. To pierce, cut, or perforate with or as with a...
II.5. intransitive. To pass into or through something readily.
II.6. transitive. To press out from surrounding material with or...
III. To strike or hit.

I. To poke or prick.

I.1.a. *transitive* and (*rare*) *intransitive*. To push, poke, prod, or nudge (esp. a person) with a stick or one's elbow. Cf. **pounce** *v.*[1] II.5. Now *rare* (U.S. in later use). **c1384–**

c1384 3e punchiden [*a*1425 *L.V.* hurliden, Latin *impingebatis*] with sydis and shuldris, and with 3our hornis wynewiden alle seek beestis.
Bible (Wycliffite, early version) (Douce MS. 369(2)) (1850) Ezekiel xxxiv. 21 ...

1440 Punchyn .., *Trudo*, *impello*.
Promptorium Parvulorum (Harley MS. 221) 416 ...

1542 Diogenes..beholding a young springal as he slept.., he pounched the same with his staffe.
N. Udall, translation of Erasmus, *Apophthegmes* i. f. cxxvii ...

1596 Pounching me with the butt end of his speare.
E. Spenser, *Second Part of Faerie Queene* vi.ii. sig. Aa5^{v} ...

?1611 With a goad he punch'd each furious dame.
G. Chapman, translation of Homer, *Iliads* vi. 126 ...

1691 2 other lords [were] puncht with the butt ends of muskets.

trebuchet

NOUN

Factsheet | Etymology | Meaning & use | Pronunciation | Forms | Frequency

QUOTATIONS

☐ Hide all quotations

CONTENTS

I. Something finely balanced, often for release.

I.1. A medieval military engine for casting heavy missiles...

I.2. † A trap or gin to catch small birds or beasts. Obsolete...

I.3. A small delicately poised balance or pair of scales; an...

II. A ducking-stool, and related uses.

II.4. An instrument of punishment, = cucking-stool, n.

EARLIER VERSION

trebuchet in OED Second Edition (1989)

I. Something finely balanced, often for release.

I.1. A medieval military engine for casting heavy missiles. *Historical.* 1388–

Described as consisting of a pivoted lever with a sling at one extremity, which was strained back against a heavy counterpoise, and then suddenly released. Cf. **catapult** *n.* 1.

[1224 Facias usque Doura maeremium ad trubechetum nostrum faciendum.
Close Roll 8 Henry III m. 4 ···]

[1224 Roellas ereas quas fieri fecistis at trubechettum nostrum.
Close Roll 9 Henry III m. 24, viij. ···]

[1377 Un trebuchet outre ascun mesure qe l'en avoit unqes veeu.
Rolls of Parliament vol. III. 10/2 ···]

α forms

1388 Thei maden arblastis, [*gloss*] ether trepeiettis, that is, an instrument for to caste schaftis, and stoonys.
Bible (Wycliffite, later version) 1 Maccabees vi. 20 ···

cloudy

ADJECTIVE

QUOTATIONS

Hide all quotations

CONTENTS

1. † Rocky; hilly. Obsolete.
2. Of cloud; of the nature of cloud.
3. Characterized by the presence of clouds; abounding in or...
4. Not transparent or clear.
5. figurative. Darkened or clouded by ignorance, etc.; (of...
6. figurative. Darkened by misfortune, grief, anger...
7. Under a cloud of disgrace or disrepute; 'shady.' colloquial.

EARLIER VERSION

cloudy, *a.* in OED Second Edition (1989)

1. † Rocky; hilly. *Obsolete.*

Old English–1400

OE Norþmanna land..is on sumum stowum swyðe cludig.
translation of Orosius, *History* i. i ···

***c*1175** I cludiȝ landess munntess.
Ormulum (Burchfield transcript) l. 2734 ···

***a*1400–50** Cloȝes at was cloude, he clynterand torres, Rochis & rogh stanes, rokkis vnfaire.
Alexander 4863 ···

❝ Cite T Historical thesaurus ▾

2.a. Of cloud; of the nature of cloud.

c1300–

***c*1300** Cloudi and berninge smoke.
St. Brandan 495 ···

1535 He spake vnto them out of the cloudy piler.
Bible (Coverdale) Psalms xcix. 7 ···

Zoom

VERB[2]

Factsheet | Etymology | Meaning & use | Pronunciation | Forms

QUOTATIONS

Hide all quotations

CONTENTS

intransitive and transitive. To communicate with (a person...

intransitive and *transitive*. To communicate with (a person or group of people) over the internet, typically by video-chatting, using the Zoom application. **2014–**

2014 RRHS Marine Honors Students ‘zooming’ with a research vessel in the South China Sea!
@MariaSwanson5 13 February in *twitter.com* (accessed 11 June 2020)

2019 I am zooming my friend.
@taramcallister4 19 December in *twitter.com* (accessed 11 June 2020)

2020 By now, most of us have probably Zoomed, especially since the Coronavirus pandemic has forced most of us to stay and work from home over the last few months.
Newstex Blogs (Nexis) 13 April ...

“ Cite

computing

Lexical Meaning

Why study semantics? Semantics (as the study of meaning) is central to the study of communication; and as communication becomes more and more a crucial factor in social organization, the need to understand it becomes more and more pressing. Semantics is also at the centre of the study of the human mind – thought processes, cognition, conceptualization – all these are intricately bound up with the way in which we classify and convey our experience of the world through language.

Leech 1981: ix

Lexical Meaning

If we ask where the meanings of words exist, the answer must be: in the minds of native speakers of the language.

Saeed 2003: 6

How Do Words *Mean*?



- Words – like *banana* – have a relationship between the word as a thing made up of letters and sounds and the thing in the world it refers to.
- Debates about the relationship between words and things take into account:
  1. The *form* of the word (its sound or written image)
  2. The *referent* (the thing to which the word refers)
  3. The *concept* (the mental abstraction which the form articulates)

How Do Words *Mean*?

concept

form

referent

How Do Words *Mean*?

concept

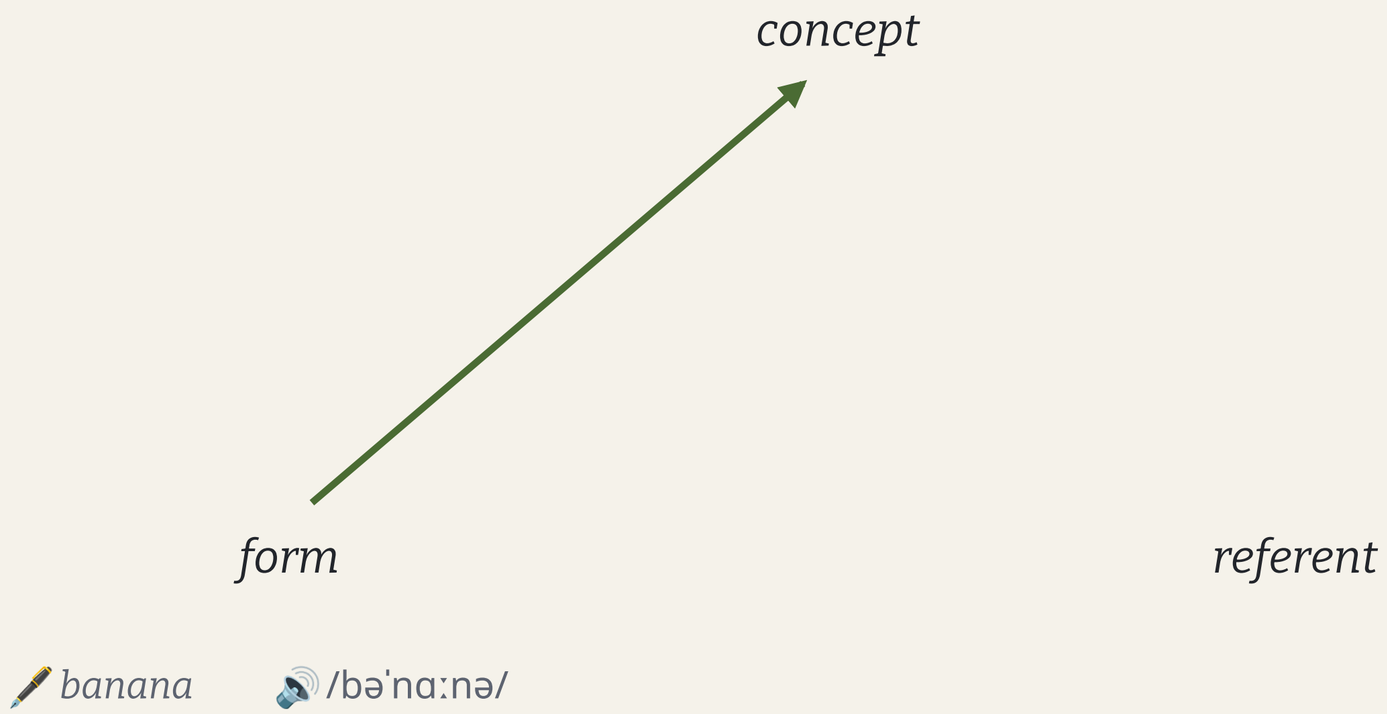
form

referent

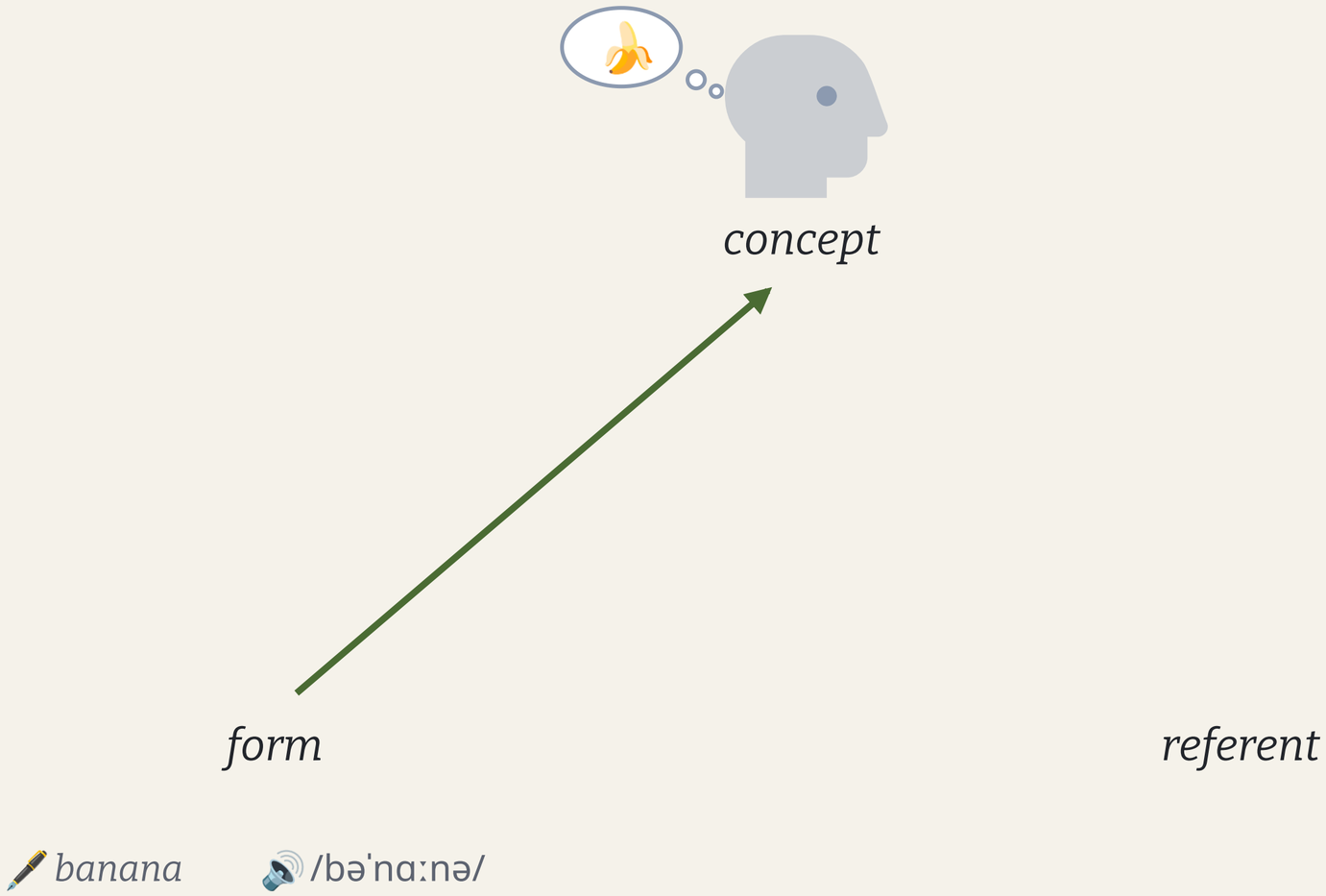
🖋 *banana*

🔊 /bəˈnɑːnə/

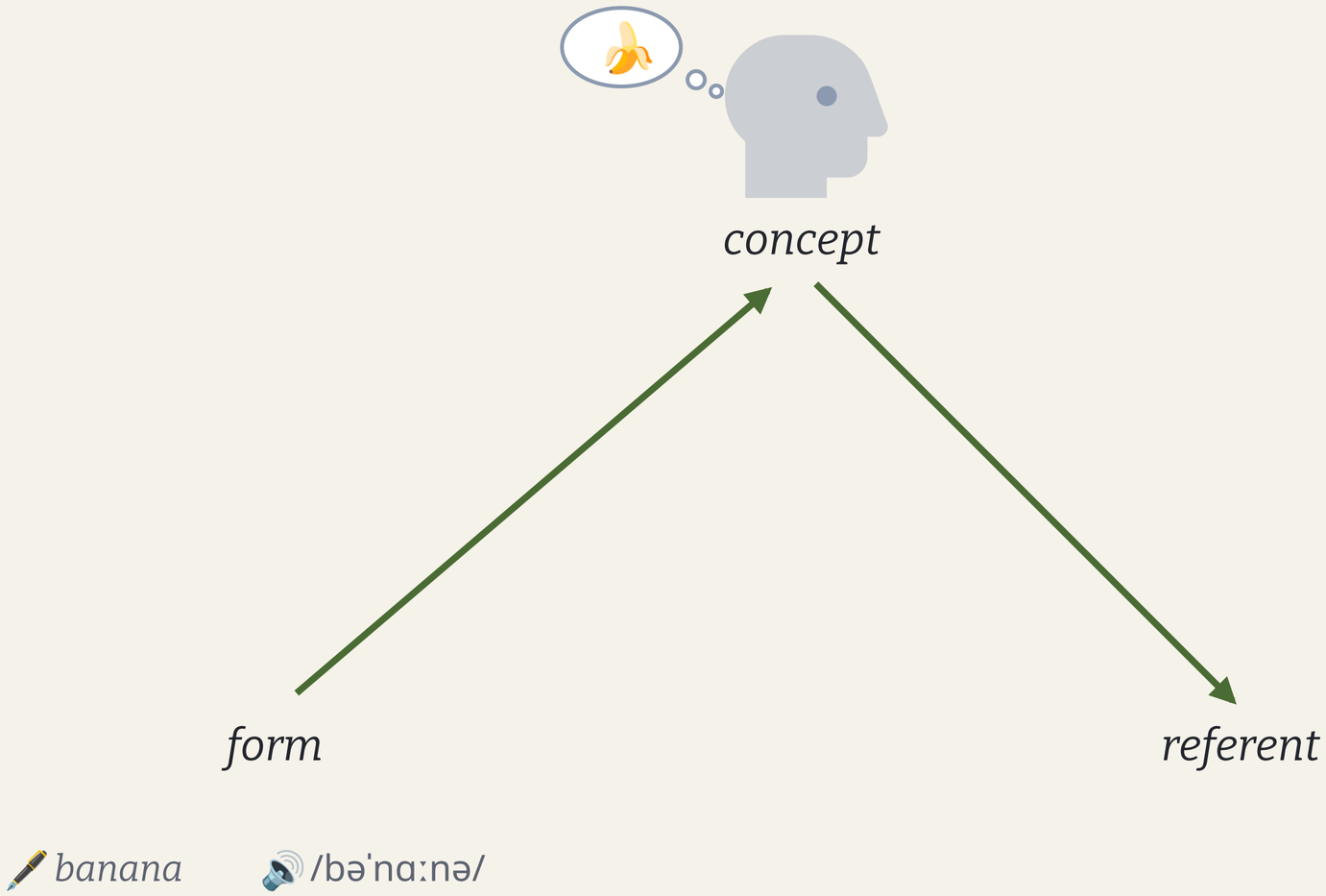
How Do Words *Mean*?



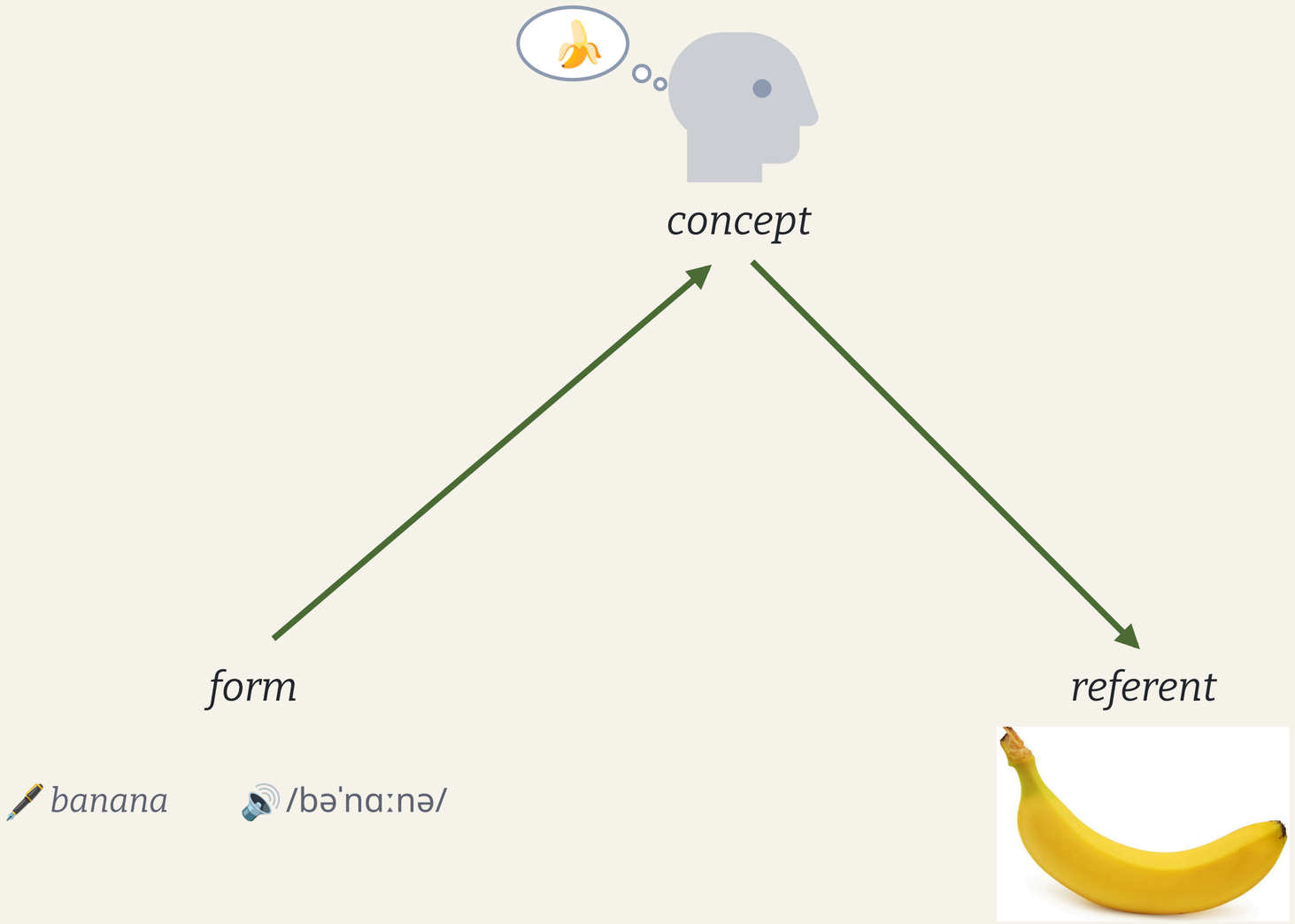
How Do Words *Mean*?



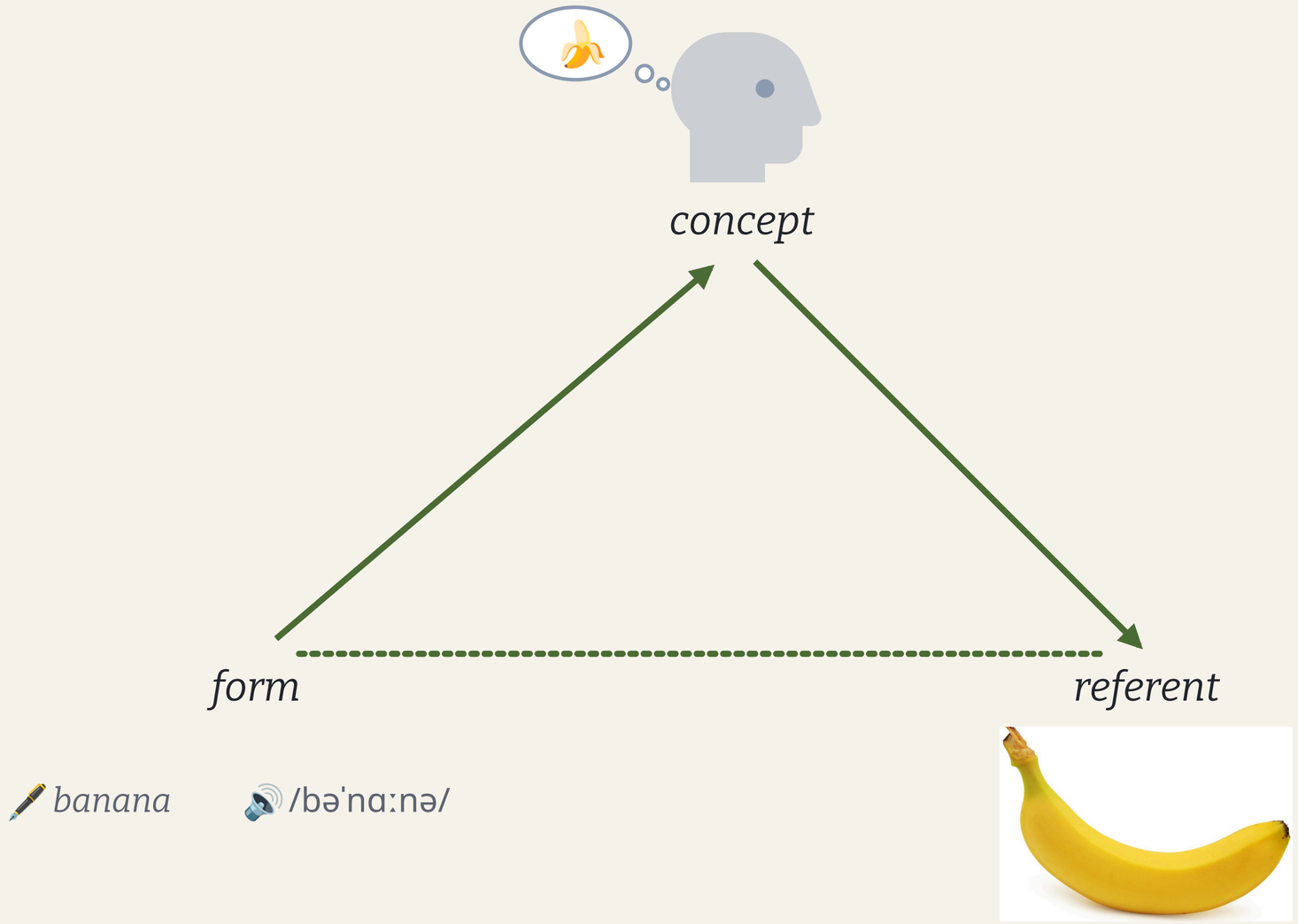
How Do Words *Mean*?



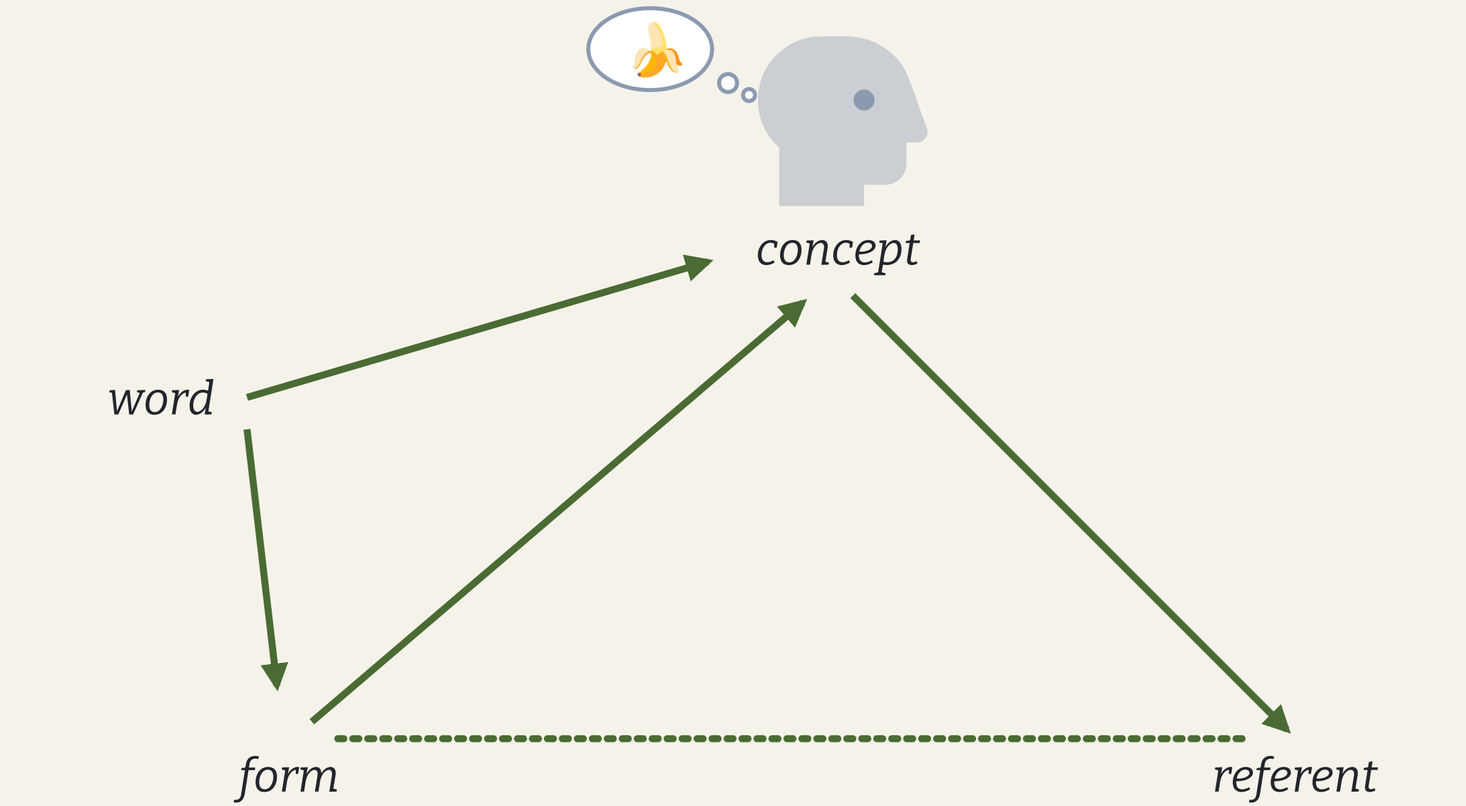
How Do Words *Mean*?



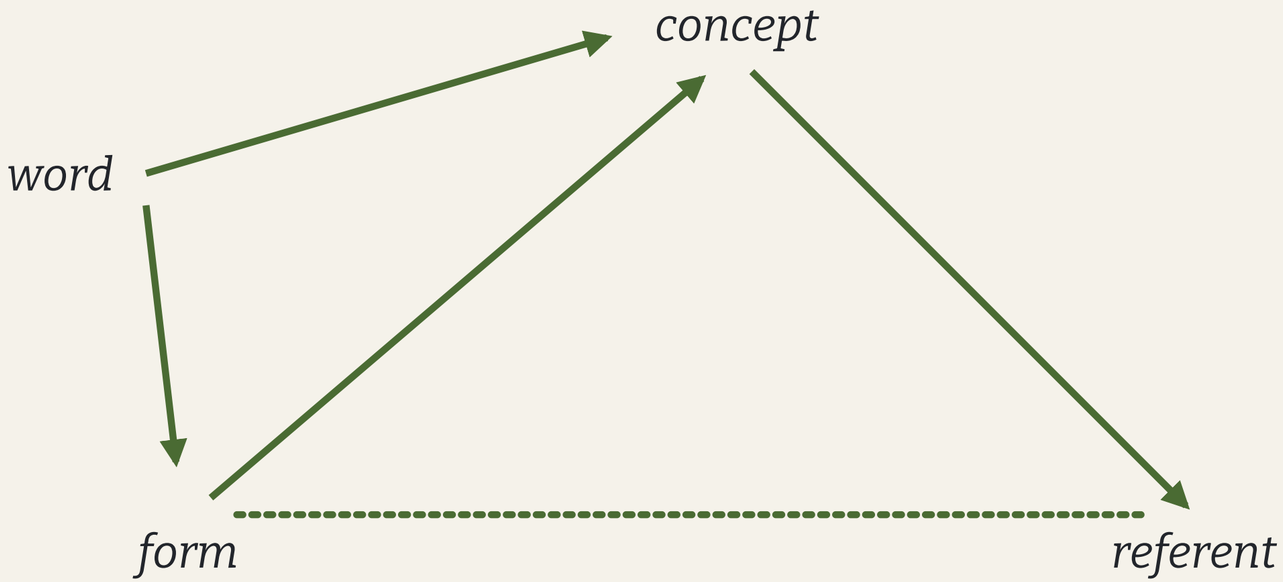
How Do Words *Mean*?



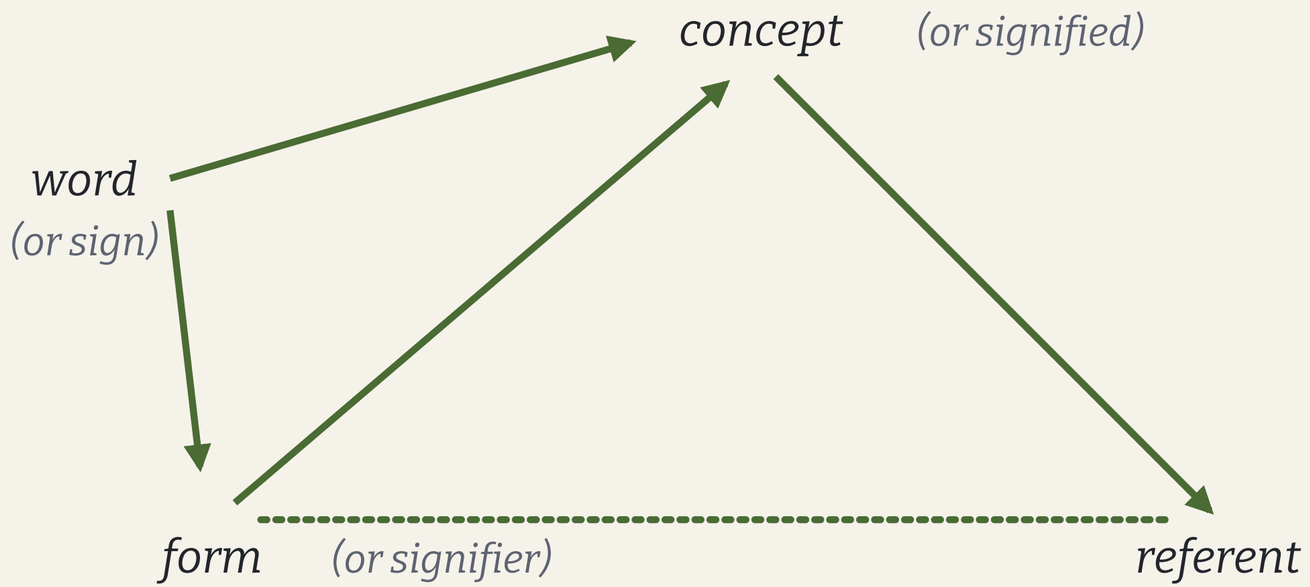
Where is the *word*?



The Semiotic Triangle



The Semiotic Triangle



Form and Referent

- The relationship between the *form* and the *referent* is a dashed line because there is (usually) **not a direct relationship** between the word's form and its referent


DOG

Form and Referent

- English: *dog*
- Dutch: *hond*
- Finnish: *koira*
- German: *Hund*
- Hawaiian: *ʻīlio*
- Icelandic: *hundur*
- Italian: *cane*



- Japanese: 犬
- Mandarin: 狗
- Korean: 개
- Arabic: *الكلب*
- Hebrew: כֶּלֶב
- Greek: *σκύλος*
- Russian: *собака*

Usually not a relationship

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Onomatopoeia**, which means the mimicry of a concept by a word, such as *bang, splash, quack*, etc.


HOW TO SOUND LIKE A DUCK IN 7 LANGUAGES
by JAMES CHAPMAN
QUACK
(ENGLISH)
RAP
(DANISH)
MAC
(ROMANIAN)
HÁP
(HUNGARIAN)
VAK
(TURKISH)
COIN
(FRENCH)
PRÄÄKS
(ESTONIAN)
CHAPMANGAMO.TUMBLR.COM

Usually not a relationship

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Phonaesthesia**, which means when words expressing similar concepts share some characteristics of form
  - Many English words referring to a reflection of light from a surface begin with *gl-* (including *glint, glisten, gleam, glitter, glow*)
  - Many words to do with uncomfortable or twisting movement begin with *wr-* (including *writhing, wrenching, wresting, wringing, wreathing, wrying, writher, wriggle, wrinkle*)
  - Many words to do with wetness often begin with *sl-* (including *slurp, slake, slobber, slippery, slime, slop, slush, sludge, slide, sledge, slick, slither, slope, slalom*), etc.

How do you define a word?

- Because of the semiotic triangle, we know that we define words by combining a *concept* and a *form*.
- So when confronted with a form, we can refer to the concept by:
  - describing a set of characteristics of the concept, or
  - by pointing to a typical example (this is an *ostensive definition*)
- The concept part of a word does not lie itself in the examples, but through encountering examples we can come up with that concept. (And sometimes update it, as we'll see in week 10.)

Finding Examples

- When you give an ostensive definition, what example do you choose?
- Draw a *tree* so that you can use it as an ostensive definition.



Dragon’s blood tree (*Dracaena cinnabari*)



Joshua tree (*Yucca brevifolia*)



Finding Examples

- What about a *house*?



Wikimedia Commons

Prototypes

- How many of you actually live in a house like this?
  - Detached
  - Two stories
  - Smoke coming from a chimney
- How many of you would say things like “I’m going back to the house now” when you mean a flat?
- What is the definition of a *house*?

NOUN

I. A building for habitation, and related senses.

I.1.a. A building for human habitation, typically and historically one that is the ordinary place of residence of a family. (Cf. **home** *n.*[1] A.I.2.)

Sometimes (with capital initial) in the names of individual residences, esp. large mansions or country houses.

With *the*: a person's home.

Prototypes

- Shared typical features of a *set* create a *categorisation*
- We do this through our experience of the world as speakers
- But not all members are equally typical of the set
- Central, typical, members of a set are called prototypes
- We can usually get agreement from speakers of a particular variety as to the central members of a set

Vegetables

- Write down the first three typical vegetables you can think of
- When this experiment was done with US college students: *carrot, pea, corn, bean, potato, tomato, lettuce, spinach, asparagus, broccoli*

Prototypes

- Prototypes represent categories of sets
- Almost all sets are *fuzzy*
- Items on the edges of a fuzzy set can be arguable:
  - Centre of the set we call *birds*: sparrow, robin, blackbird, crow
  - Edge of the set: ostrich, penguin
  - Share some characteristics but definitely not: bats, aeroplanes
  - Have an argument over: dinosaurs

21 DECEMBER 2021

It’s official: birds are literally dinosaurs. Here’s how we know

Preventing Extinctions: bringing the world’s most threatened birds back from the brink

Species



BirdLife International, 21 December 2021





Follow-up

- This week, you should look under the *Meaning* heading in the online reading list (on Moodle) and sample a few introductory chapters from books on semantics.
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (email me for a time!).